



The Competitive Advantage of Differences

Cognitive Diversity as a Strategic Framework for Innovation and Performance

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The Competitive Advantage of Differences

Cognitive Diversity as a Strategic Framework for Innovation and Performance





The biggest challenges for Organizations are perception challenges



What if the difference in thinking wasn't a problem...

...but a competitive advantage?



Cognitive Diversity

Cognitive diversity is the variety of ways to:

Perceive

How each mind grasps the world around it

Interpret

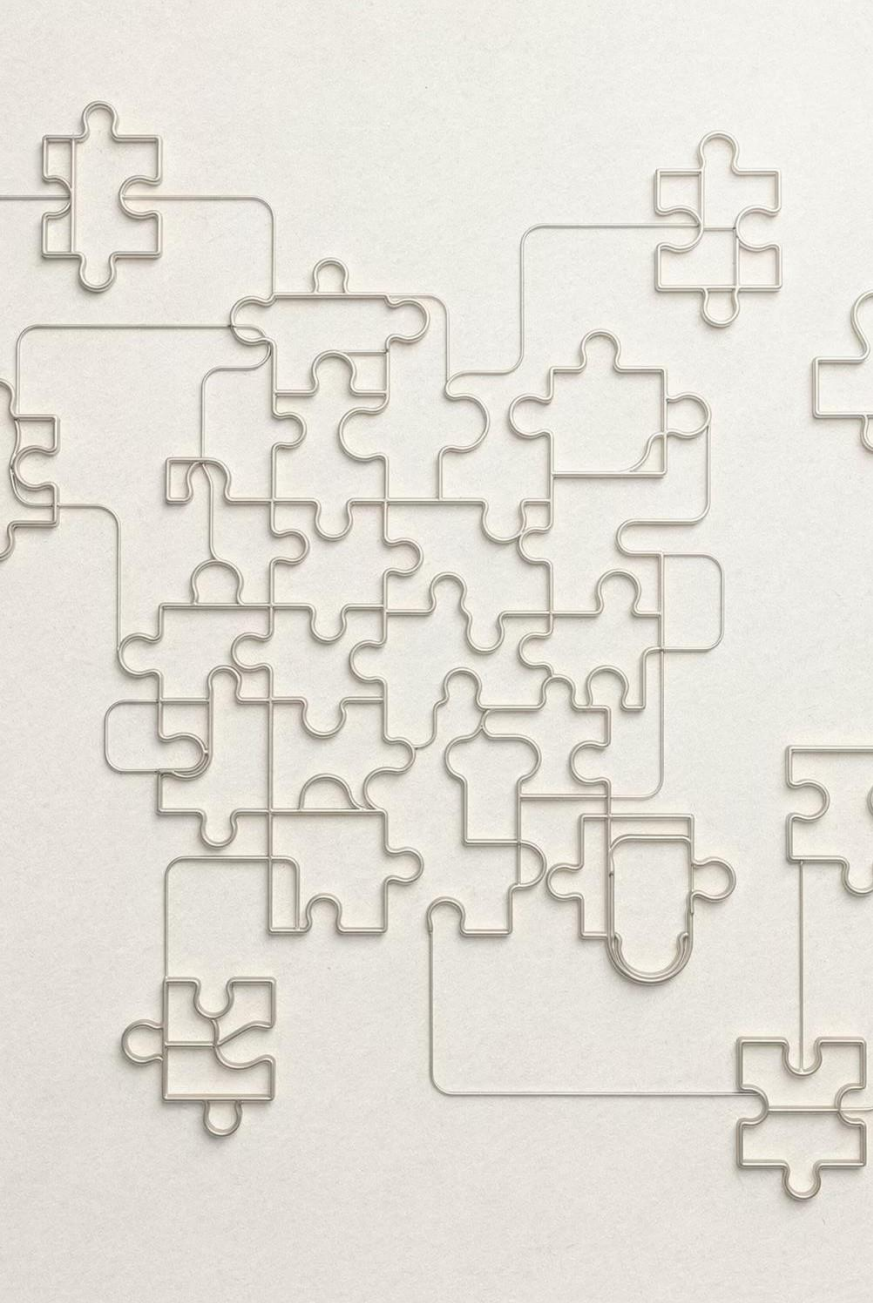
How each mind assigns meaning to information

Decide

How each mind chooses between alternatives

Act

How each mind translates thought into action



Complex
problems require
diversity of
thought.

Hong & Page, 2004 (PNAS)



I lived this.

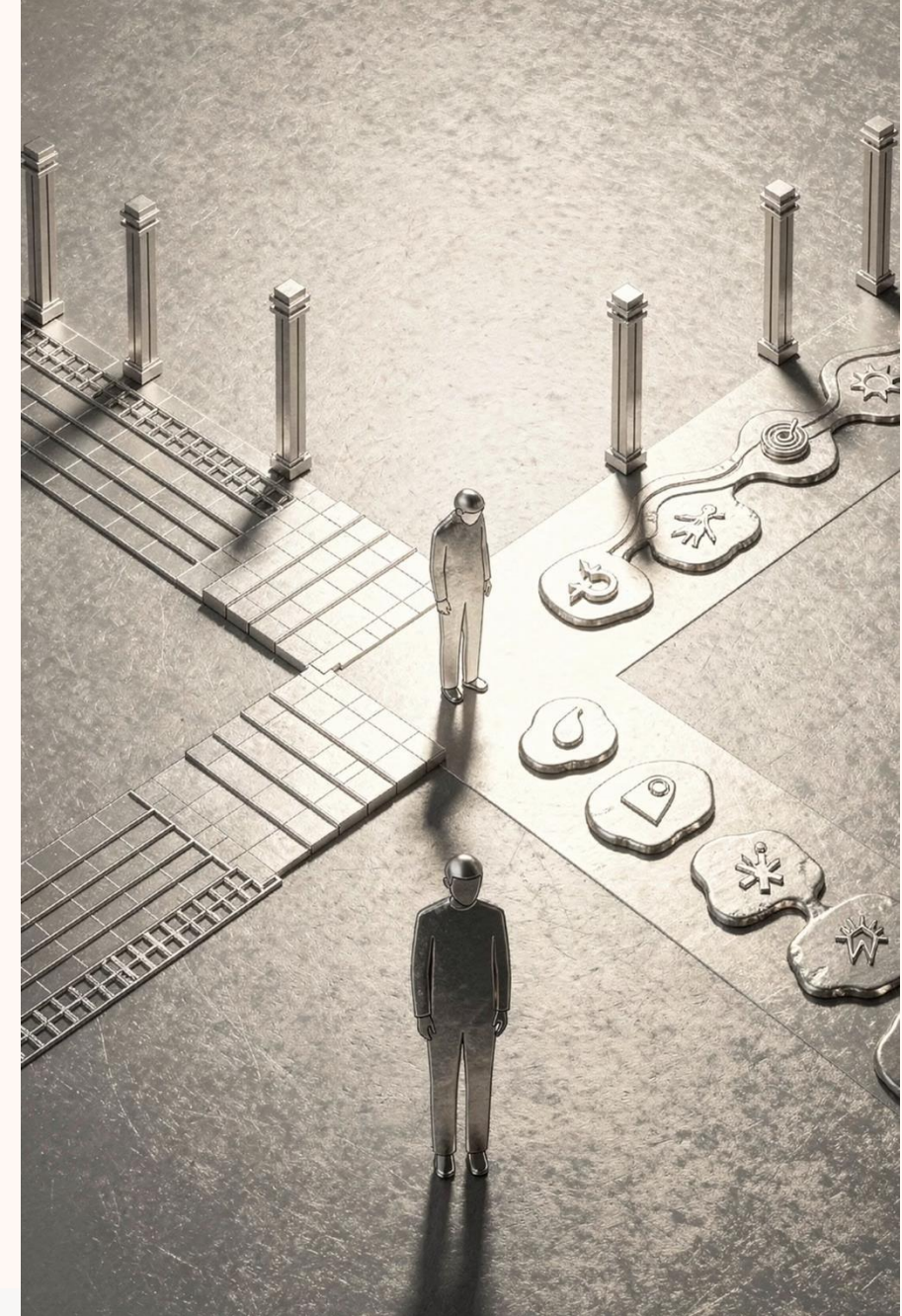
I have ADHD.





The problem was in my difference...

or in the
system?





Neurodiversity

Cognitive differences can generate:

Innovation

New ways of seeing old problems

Creativity

Unexpected connections between distant ideas

New Solutions

Answers that homogeneous minds cannot reach

❏ "When the context allows, neurodiversity transforms into Competitive advantage."

Austin & Pisano, 2017 (HBR)



Homogeneity

Similar teams:

They decide fast. They agree fast.

But they see little.



GROUPTHINK

Without contrast, consensus can
turn into blindness.

Janis, 1972



Diversity alone does not
generate high performance



Difference with belongingness transforms outcomes



Belongingness

Belongingness is a
fundamental human
need.

Maslow, 1943



Without belongingness



Illness
of the body



Delivery
without
soul



Erosion of
identity



Defensiveness

Baumeister & Leary, 1995



*"Lack of belongingness
reduces well-being,
compromises the integrity of
the self and the power of
deliveries"*

Carla Zanna



In every **achievement** there is
a dose **of happiness**.
And in every **happiness**
there is an experience of
achievement.

Harris & Orth,
2019



Health and Relationships

The quality of our relationships impacts:

Health

Energy

Longevity



Umberson & Montez, 2010



When these elements integrate,
diversity becomes a result.



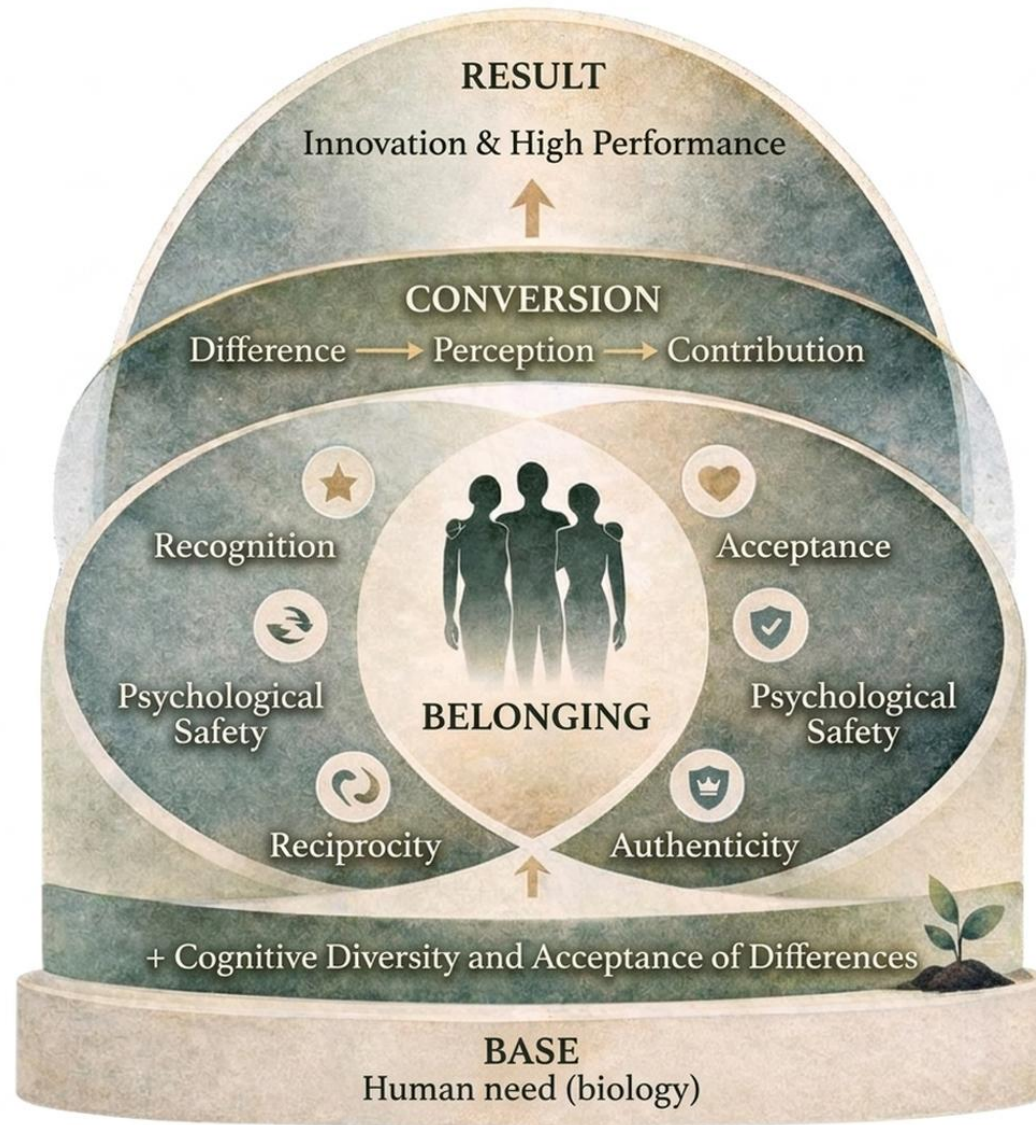
Psychological Safety
Difference only
becomes a
contribution when
there is safety to
emerge.





Architecture of Belongingness

Belongingness is not a cultural value. It is an **invisible** infrastructure that supports **performance.**





An Integrated System

Think

Cognition and
analysis



Feel

Emotion and
belongingness

Act

Decision and
performance



3 movements for leaders

WHAT TO DO IN PRACTICE

- 1** Create safety for differences to emerge

Ask, listen, and react in a way that encourages — not silences.
- 2** Redesign processes so that different ways of thinking have room to contribute

Formats, rituals, and decisions need to accommodate varied cognitive styles.
- 3** Include belongingness as a performance indicator

Not just climate. Belongingness is strategic data.



Competitive advantage
lies in people and
how you manage to
Integrate them



Thank you very
much!

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Thank you!

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